

When Models Know They Are Being Tested: A Scoping Review of Evaluation Awareness, Sandbagging and Related Model-Originated Threats to the Validity of Large Language Model Evaluation

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Abstract

Evaluations of large language models (LLMs) increasingly inform deployment and governance decisions, yet models can recognise evaluation contexts and behave differently in them. We searched Scopus, arXiv and Semantic Scholar on 9 October 2026 and supplemented them with logged web searches. From 5649 database and 418 web records, 315 studies (2022–2026) met the eligibility criteria; we read the full texts of 37 anchor studies and checked every quantitative claim about them. We propose a four-layer framework (context signal, awareness, behavioural divergence, validity consequence) and formalise it as a decomposition of evaluation error into task, model-originated and scorer components. The decomposition shows that context separability is necessary for model-originated bias, that awareness is neither necessary nor sufficient for a biased score, and that behavioural divergence cannot be identified from evaluation-condition data alone. Three empirical findings stand out. First, evaluation awareness is not a single quantity: elicited, verbalised and represented measures diverge, and probe evidence is confounded by prompt format. Second, the awareness–behaviour link is real but heterogeneous in magnitude and direction across models. Third, black-box detection of strategic underperformance remains unreliable, whereas fine-tuning and, recently, activation-level elicitation recover capability from induced sandbaggers. The evidence base is young and preprint-dominated, many agent benchmarks are themselves exploitable, and validation rests almost entirely on deliberately induced behaviour. We derive an evidence-graded research agenda and a twelve-item reporting checklist for evaluation papers and system cards.

Keywords: Evaluation awareness · Sandbagging · Large language models · AI safety evaluation · Construct validity · Alignment faking

1 Introduction

Evaluations are the main instrument through which developers, independent evaluators and regulators decide what a large language model (LLM) can do and how it is likely to behave. Frontier developers condition deployment and safeguard decisions on dangerous-capability and alignment evaluations (Phuong et al. 2024; OpenAI 2025b; Anthropic 2025b), and third-party evaluators increasingly publish pre-deployment assessments (METR 2025a; Souly et al. 2026). Every such decision rests on an inferential step that is rarely stated: that behaviour observed under evaluation is representative of behaviour in deployment.

That step has always been vulnerable to familiar threats such as benchmark contamination, weak construct validity and prompt sensitivity (Raji et al. 2021; Sclar et al. 2024; Bean et al. 2025). This review concerns a different class of threat, one that originates in the evaluated model itself. A model that can recognise that it is being tested may behave differently because it is being tested. Concretely, it may underperform on a

capability evaluation (sandbagging), present a more aligned profile on a safety evaluation (alignment or evaluation faking), produce outputs that deceive the scoring pipeline (strategic dishonesty), or exploit the test harness (evaluator gaming). Each of these breaks the link between the reported score and the deployment behaviour the score is meant to predict.

Concern about this possibility is longstanding in the alignment literature (Hubinger et al. 2019; Carlsmith 2023; Ngo et al. 2024), but empirical work on it has grown sharply only since 2024. Models have been shown to underperform selectively when prompted or fine-tuned to do so (van der Weij et al. 2025); frontier models discriminate evaluation transcripts from deployment transcripts well above chance (Needham et al. 2025); linear probes recover an evaluation-versus-deployment distinction from model activations (Nguyen et al. 2025); and developers now report evaluation-awareness measurements in their system cards (Anthropic 2025a; OpenAI 2025a). At the same time, the field acknowledges that it lacks a shared conceptual foundation: studies conflate properties of the evaluation with properties of the model, and detection with behavioural response (Li C et al. 2026).

Existing reviews do not address this gap directly. Surveys of AI deception catalogue deceptive behaviours broadly but predate most of the evaluation-awareness literature or treat it as one behaviour among many (Park et al. 2024; Shi et al. 2026; Chen B et al. 2025). A 2026 review of the AI “observer effect” is closest in theme, but synthesises fifteen landmark contributions published up to 2024 and predates the measurement literature on evaluation awareness (Maurya et al. 2026). Broad reviews of safety-evaluation methods and of reward hacking name sandbagging or evaluator gaming as challenges without synthesising how they are measured (Grey and Segerie 2025; Wang X et al. 2026; Morampudi et al. 2026). A recent hybrid survey frames benchmark validity and alignment failure as a common proxy–target divergence problem across eight evidence streams (Uluurmak and Kurban 2026), but it does not centre on model-originated threats or on how they are measured. Reviews of benchmark validity and safety datasets address the evaluator side of the problem rather than the model side (Röttger et al. 2025; Bean et al. 2025). Section 2.4 and Table 1 give the detailed comparison.

This review asks five questions:

- **RQ1.** How are evaluation awareness, sandbagging, alignment or evaluation faking and related constructs defined and operationalised?
- **RQ2.** Which methods are used to detect or measure these phenomena, and what evidence supports their validity?
- **RQ3.** Under which model, task and context conditions are the phenomena observed, and where do findings conflict?
- **RQ4.** Which countermeasures have been proposed, and how rigorously have they been evaluated?
- **RQ5.** Which gaps most threaten the validity of current evaluation practice, and which studies would close them?

The review makes four contributions:

1. A reproducible evidence map of 315 studies on model-originated threats to LLM evaluation validity, identified through three bibliographic databases and logged web searches, with all screening decisions and counts generated by released scripts.
2. A four-layer framework (context signal, awareness, behavioural divergence, validity consequence) with explicit assignment rules, and a formal decomposition of evaluation error that states what each study

design can and cannot identify. The framework separates constructs that the literature frequently conflates.

3. A structured comparison of measurement methods and their validity evidence, and a typed analysis of seven apparent contradictions in the literature.
4. An evidence-graded research agenda and a twelve-item reporting checklist for evaluation papers and system cards.

The remainder of the paper is organised as follows. Section 2 introduces terminology and prior reviews. Section 3 describes the review method, including the protocol amendments and the two-phase identification. Section 4 reports results by research question. Section 5 discusses implications. Section 6 sets out the research agenda, Section 7 the limitations of the review, and Section 8 concludes.

2 Background and terminology

2.1 Measurement validity and observer effects

The concern addressed here is an instance of a general measurement problem. In psychometrics, validity is a property of the inferences drawn from scores rather than of the scores themselves (Messick 1995). Measurement modelling makes the same point for computational systems: unobservable constructs must be operationalised, and mismatches between a construct and its operationalisation produce systematic error (Jacobs and Wallach 2021). Benchmarks presented as general measures of progress have been criticised on exactly these grounds (Raji et al. 2021). A recent review of 445 LLM benchmarks found widespread weaknesses in how measured phenomena, tasks and metrics support the claims made from them (Bean et al. 2025).

In the human sciences, the analogous model-side threat is the observer or Hawthorne effect: participants change their behaviour because they are studied. A systematic review of that literature concluded that research-participation effects exist but that little can be securely known about their conditions, mechanisms or magnitude, and that new concepts were needed (McCambridge et al. 2014). The parallel with the current LLM literature is close, and we return to it in Section 5. A related principle, often summarised as Goodhart’s law, holds that a measure placed under optimisation pressure ceases to measure what it measured before. It has been demonstrated quantitatively for reward-model optimisation (Gao et al. 2023).

2.2 Constructs

Five constructs recur in the literature. We define them operationally here, and Section 4.3 examines how the primary studies actually use them.

- **Situational awareness:** a model’s knowledge of itself and its circumstances, including whether it is in training, testing or deployment (Berglund et al. 2023; Laine et al. 2024). It is broader than evaluation awareness.
- **Evaluation awareness:** the capability or tendency to recognise that the current context is an evaluation (Needham et al. 2025; Nguyen et al. 2025). Some authors restrict the term to recognition alone; others include the resulting behaviour.
- **Sandbagging:** strategic underperformance on an evaluation (van der Weij et al. 2025). The GPT-5 system card defines it as a model’s ability and propensity to respond to safety or capability evaluations in a way that significantly diverges from performance under real conditions (OpenAI 2025a), and OpenAI’s Preparedness Framework lists sandbagging as a research category (OpenAI 2025b).

- **Alignment faking and evaluation faking:** behaving in line with the training or evaluation objective when the model infers that it is observed, while behaving differently when it infers that it is not (Greenblatt et al. 2024a; Fan et al. 2025).
- **Evaluator gaming:** obtaining a high score by exploiting the scoring process rather than performing the intended task, including test-case exploitation, reward hacking and outputs that mislead automated graders (Zhong et al. 2026a; Panfilov et al. 2026).

2.3 Elicitation and the direction of error

A capability evaluation underestimates a model when elicitation is incomplete, whether because the model hides a capability or because the evaluators did not try hard enough. Post-training enhancements such as scaffolding, tool use and prompting can raise benchmark performance by amounts that would otherwise require several-fold more training compute (Davidson et al. 2023). Dangerous-capability evaluations therefore treat insufficient elicitation as a central threat (Phuong et al. 2024; Benton et al. 2024). Sandbagging is the adversarial limit of this problem. It is distinct from ordinary under-elicitation because the source of error is the model’s own policy. Conversely, alignment faking produces an *over-estimate* of safety. The two threats bias evaluation results in opposite directions on different evaluation types, and a review that treats them together must keep the direction of error explicit.

2.4 Prior reviews

Table 1 compares this review with the closest existing syntheses. None takes model-originated evaluation-validity threats as its primary object, and none synthesises the 2025–2026 primary literature on evaluation awareness measurement, which accounts for most of the evidence charted here (Section 4.1).

Table 1 Comparison with the closest prior reviews and syntheses (coverage judged from abstracts, and from the full text for Maurya et al. 2026)

Review	Type, status	Primary focus	Evaluation awareness as a validity threat	Measurement-method synthesis	What this review adds
Park et al. (2024)	Survey, <i>Patterns</i>	AI deception: examples, risks, solutions	Not a focus; predates most studies	No	Evaluation-centred scope; 2024–2026 evidence
Shi et al. (2026)	Taxonomy and benchmark analysis (50 benchmarks), ICLR 2026 workshop	Unified deception taxonomy mapped to benchmarks	One behaviour among many	Benchmarks, not measurement validity	Validity framework for the evaluation itself
Chen B et al. (2025)	Survey, preprint	Deception defined via signalling theory; deception cycle	Partial	No	Measurement-method comparison and contradictions
Uluirmak and Kurban (2026)	Hybrid survey (373 studies), preprint	Proxy–target divergence across eight evidence streams	Touched (strategic behaviour, alignment faking)	Broad; not awareness-specific	Model-side mechanisms; awareness measurement; reporting checklist

Review	Type, status	Primary focus	Evaluation awareness as a validity threat	Measurement-method synthesis	What this review adds
Maurya et al. (2026)	Review of 15 selected contributions (2016–2024), <i>IJSRCSEIT</i>	“Observer effect”: behaviour when unmonitored	Central, but conceptual; studies to 2024 only	No; narrative synthesis of landmark studies selected from Google Scholar, arXiv and developer repositories	Logged multi-database search; 2025–2026 measurement literature; comparability classes and reporting checklist
Grey and Segerie (2025)	Systematic literature review, preprint	Taxonomy of AI safety evaluations (capabilities, propensities, control)	Named as a challenge (sandbagging)	Broad taxonomy of evaluation techniques	Threat-specific synthesis of how sandbagging and awareness are measured and detected
Wang X et al. (2026); Morampudi et al. (2026)	Surveys, preprint; <i>Discover Artificial Intelligence</i>	Reward hacking in RLHF/RLVR and in agentic systems	Not a focus	Detection and mitigation of reward hacking	Reward hacking treated as one evaluator-gaming pathway within a validity framework
Frontier Model Forum (2025)	Industry technical report	Practice of frontier capability assessment	Elicitation and validity in general	No systematic evidence map	Documented evidence map
Röttger et al. (2025)	Systematic review (144 datasets), AAAI	Open safety-evaluation datasets	No	Dataset landscape	Model-originated threats
Bean et al. (2025)	Systematic review (445 benchmarks), NeurIPS	Construct validity of LLM benchmarks	No	Benchmark design	Model-side threats complementary to construct validity

3 Review methodology

3.1 Design, protocol and amendments

A protocol (v0.1) was written before any formal searching. It specified a scoping review reported according to PRISMA-ScR (Tricco et al. 2018), using the framework of Arksey and O’Malley (2005) as refined by Levac et al. (2010). A scoping design was chosen because terminology in the field is inconsistent, study designs are heterogeneous, and the objective is to map concepts, methods and gaps rather than to pool effects. The protocol was not registered. The selection process is reported with a PRISMA 2020 flow diagram that separates database searches from other identification methods (Page et al. 2021).

Identification took place in two phases on 9 October 2026. In the first phase, the bibliographic APIs named in the protocol were unreachable from the computing environment, so records were identified through 25 logged web-search batches (identification via other methods). In the second phase, after network access was opened, the protocol’s database searches were executed. Protocol amendment v0.2, made before the database searches were run and recorded with a timestamp in the released query file, (a) added Scopus as an information source, (b) added the model-originated threat terms “strategic deception”, “strategic dishonesty” and “deceptive alignment”, and (c) added “reward hacking” and “specification gaming” in combination with an evaluation term, to match the scope that the first phase had shown to be necessary. The search strategy was then frozen. Two planned sources could not be searched: OpenAlex returned HTTP 429 (daily quota

exhausted) and DBLP returned an anti-automation page instead of results. Both failures are logged (Supplementary File S1b).

3.2 Eligibility criteria

Table 2 summarises the eligibility criteria. In brief, sources were eligible if they (I1) were primary empirical studies, methodological or benchmark papers, or developer or third-party evaluation reports; (I2) measured, induced, detected or mitigated behaviour that depends on evaluation context, or strategic or induced underperformance, in LLMs or LLM-based agents; and (I3) reported enough method detail for the charting fields.

Table 2 Eligibility criteria and screening codes

Code	Criterion	Applied at
I1	Primary study, method/benchmark paper, or developer/third-party evaluation report	Title, abstract, metadata
I2	Phenomenon: evaluation-context-dependent behaviour, strategic or induced underperformance, or a method to detect, elicit or mitigate it in LLMs or LLM agents	Title, abstract, metadata
I3	Method details sufficient to chart framework layer and method family	Title and abstract (full text for the anchor set)
Period	1 January 2019 to 9 October 2026	Metadata
E1	Different construct (e.g. environmental situational awareness), or a method unrelated to evaluation validity	Title, abstract
E3	Non-archival community forum post or informal blog without an organisational or archival report	Venue
E6	Title or identifier could not be confirmed from retrieved records	Metadata
S1	No phenomenon term of the frozen query in title or abstract (rule-assisted pre-screen, audited)	Title, abstract
R0	Duplicate identifier or version of the same work	Identifier, title
CONTEXT	Eligible publication outside the phenomenon boundary (methodology, background theory, adjacent evaluation-validity literature such as contamination, jailbreak scoring or benchmark design); cited for context, not charted	Title, abstract

Training-data contamination was deliberately placed outside the phenomenon boundary. It is a data-side rather than a model-side threat, and it has been reviewed recently (e.g. Chen S et al. 2025). Contamination studies were retained as context.

3.3 Information sources and search

Databases. Three sources were searched on 9 October 2026 through their APIs: Scopus (Elsevier Search API, field TITLE-ABS-KEY), arXiv (export API, abstract field, restricted to cs.CL, cs.AI, cs.LG and cs.CR) and Semantic Scholar (Academic Graph bulk search over titles and abstracts). Together they cover the peer-

reviewed venues indexed by Scopus, the preprint server on which most of this literature first appears, and the conference proceedings (NeurIPS, ICML, ICLR, ACL) indexed by Semantic Scholar. The query combined three concept blocks: system terms (A: language model(s), LLM(s), foundation model, frontier model, AI agent, AI system); phenomenon terms specific enough to stand alone (B1: evaluation awareness, eval awareness, test awareness, sandbagging, strategic underperformance, alignment faking, evaluation faking, observer effect, evaluation gaming, under-elicitation, password-locked, hidden capabilities, strategic deception, strategic dishonesty, deceptive alignment); and broader phenomenon terms that were admitted only with an evaluation term (B2: situational awareness, scheming, capability elicitation, reward hacking, specification gaming; C: evaluation, benchmark, test, assessment, audit). The logical form was A AND (B1 OR (B2 AND C)), limited to publications from 1 January 2019. The exact strings submitted to each API, the retrieval timestamps and the record counts are given in Supplementary File S1b, and the raw API responses are released.

Other methods. The first-phase web searches comprised 133 queries in 25 record-identifying batches and one metadata-verification batch. They covered seven concept areas: evaluation and situational awareness; sandbagging and capability elicitation; alignment faking, scheming and sabotage evaluations; reward hacking and evaluator gaming; reasoning-trace monitoring and faithfulness; white-box detection; and system cards, third-party evaluations and governance. Known-item searches checked the metadata of sources cited by included studies (backward citation chasing). Developer system cards and third-party evaluation reports, which bibliographic databases do not index, were identified only by this route. Every query and the records it yielded are listed in Supplementary File S1a.

3.4 Selection

Deduplication. Database records were deduplicated automatically on DOI, version-stripped arXiv identifier and normalised title plus year (search/dedup.py). Title pairs with a similarity of at least 0.93 were flagged, and 30 flagged pairs that were versions of the same work (for example, a preprint and its proceedings version) were merged after manual inspection. Web records were matched to database records on the same keys, and records found by both routes are counted once, in the databases column of the flow diagram.

Stage 1 (rule-assisted pre-screen). Semantic Scholar’s bulk search stems query terms (for example, “scheming” also retrieves “scheme”), which inflated the number of irrelevant records. Records whose title and abstract contained none of the phenomenon terms of the frozen query, written as a fixed regular expression (Supplementary File S2), were therefore excluded at stage 1. To check this rule, a random sample of 120 stage-1 exclusions (seed 20261009) was read in full at title and abstract level. It contained one relevant record (0.8%; Wilson 95% CI 0.2–4.6%). A rescue pass then applied a broader pattern to all stage-1 exclusions, and the 399 records it matched were screened manually.

Stage 2 (title and abstract). All records that passed stage 1 or were flagged by the rescue pass were screened manually against Table 2. Each record received one decision code. Records in the first-phase web set were screened on titles, venues and retrieved summaries using the same criteria.

Reconciliation and reliability. Ninety web records were also retrieved by the databases and had therefore been screened twice, once in each phase, without access to the earlier decision. The two passes agreed on 84 of the 90 records (93.3%; Cohen’s $\kappa = 0.747$; Cohen 1960). The six discordant records were re-read and resolved by consensus; five became included studies and one a contextual reference. Screening was performed by a single reviewer working with an AI system (see the AI-use statement); there was no dual

independent screening. The safeguards were the frozen rules, the audited stage-1 sample with a rescue pass, the inter-pass reliability check and a complete decision log (Supplementary File S2; screening/).

3.5 Data charting

For each included study, the following were charted: identifier, title, first author or organisation, year, venue, source type (peer-reviewed, preprint, grey literature), framework layer and method family (Section 3.6). Studies identified only through the databases were charted manually from title and abstract (screening/db_charting_manual.tsv).

For a purposive anchor set of 37 primary studies that carry the field’s main empirical claims, the full texts were retrieved (latest arXiv version as of 9 October 2026) and read. For each one we charted:

- the construct name used;
- the setting;
- the models evaluated;
- the main result;
- the design features reported, namely a control or counterfactual condition, more than one model family, and ground truth by construction.

Every quantitative statement about an anchor study in Sections 4 and 5 was checked against the full text. Statements about other studies rest on their abstracts and are worded accordingly.

3.6 Framework derivation and assignment rules

An initial framework was formulated in the protocol, separating the evaluation-context signal, model awareness, behavioural divergence and the validity consequence. It was then revised inductively during charting; for example, reasoning-trace monitoring was split from white-box methods after charting showed that the two have distinct validity problems. Each source was assigned to one primary layer according to its main object of study:

- **L1** studies manipulate or characterise properties of the evaluation;
- **L2** studies measure whether models recognise evaluation;
- **L3** studies measure behaviour conditional on that recognition, or strategic underperformance or misreporting;
- **L4** studies propose or test responses (detection, elicitation, suppression, environment redesign, training interventions) or report validity consequences in developer or third-party evaluations.

For studies identified in the first phase, method families were assigned by documented keyword rules applied to the title and recorded scope, with 30 manual overrides for multi-method studies whose titles do not reveal their primary method (evidence/chart.py). Studies identified only in the database phase were assigned a layer and a method family manually from their abstracts. To check the rule-based layer assignment, the 37 anchor studies were also coded manually from their full texts: the two assignments agreed for 34 of 37 studies (91.9%; $\kappa = 0.881$; screening/reliability.py). Single-layer assignment necessarily simplifies multi-method studies; Section 7 discusses the consequences.

3.7 Critical appraisal and synthesis

Formal risk-of-bias assessment is not required for scoping reviews, and no validated tool exists for the designs in this field. We did not compute quality scores. Instead, the full-text charting of the anchor set

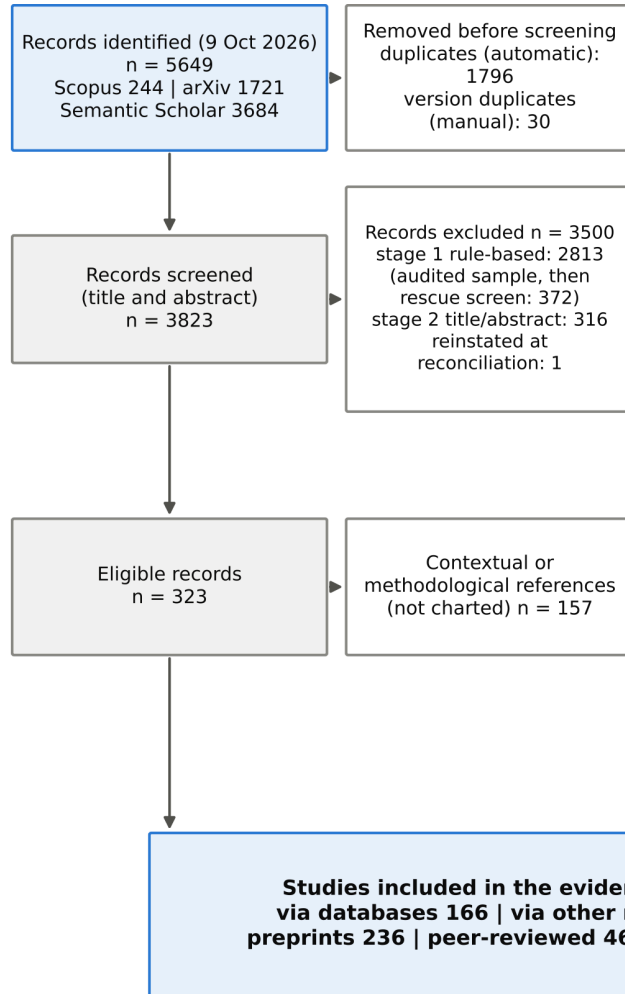
records which design features each study reports, and Section 4 discusses evidential weight qualitatively. Before any cross-study statement, findings were classified as directly comparable (same construct, measure and model), conditionally comparable (same construct but different measure or model) or non-comparable. No effect sizes were pooled and no leaderboards were constructed. Apparent disagreements were typed as a genuine contradiction, context-dependent, a metric artefact, a methodological artefact, or insufficient evidence (Table 7).

4 Results

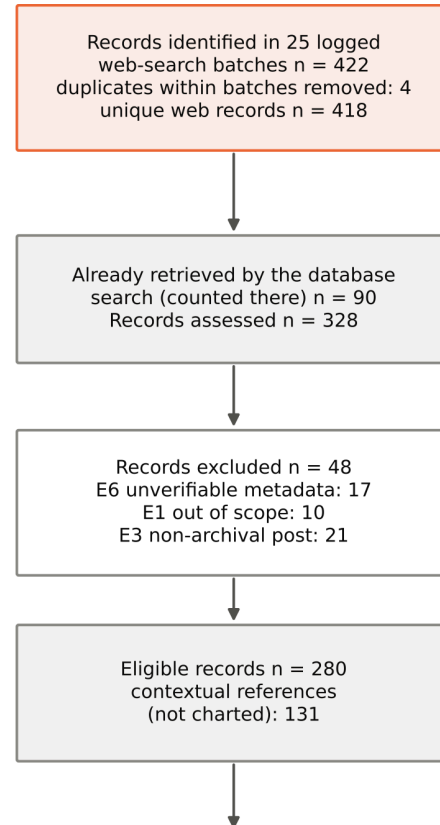
4.1 Evidence landscape

The database searches retrieved 5649 records (Scopus 244, arXiv 1721, Semantic Scholar 3684). After removing 1796 duplicates automatically and 30 version duplicates manually, 3823 records were screened. Stage 1 excluded 2813 records, after the audit and the rescue pass, and stage 2 excluded 316 on title and abstract; one of these was reinstated at reconciliation. Of the 323 eligible database records, 157 fell outside the phenomenon boundary and were retained as contextual or methodological references, and 166 were included. The web searches added 418 unique records, of which 90 had already been retrieved by the databases. Of the remaining 328, 48 were excluded (17 E6, 10 E1, 21 E3), 131 were retained as context and 149 were included. The evidence map therefore comprises 315 studies (Fig. 1). Of the 224 studies included from the web phase, 75 (33.5%) were also retrieved by the database search. Most of the others belong to evidence streams that the database query was not designed to retrieve, such as chain-of-thought faithfulness, probing and AI control, or are developer and third-party reports that bibliographic databases do not index.

Identification via databases



Identification via other methods



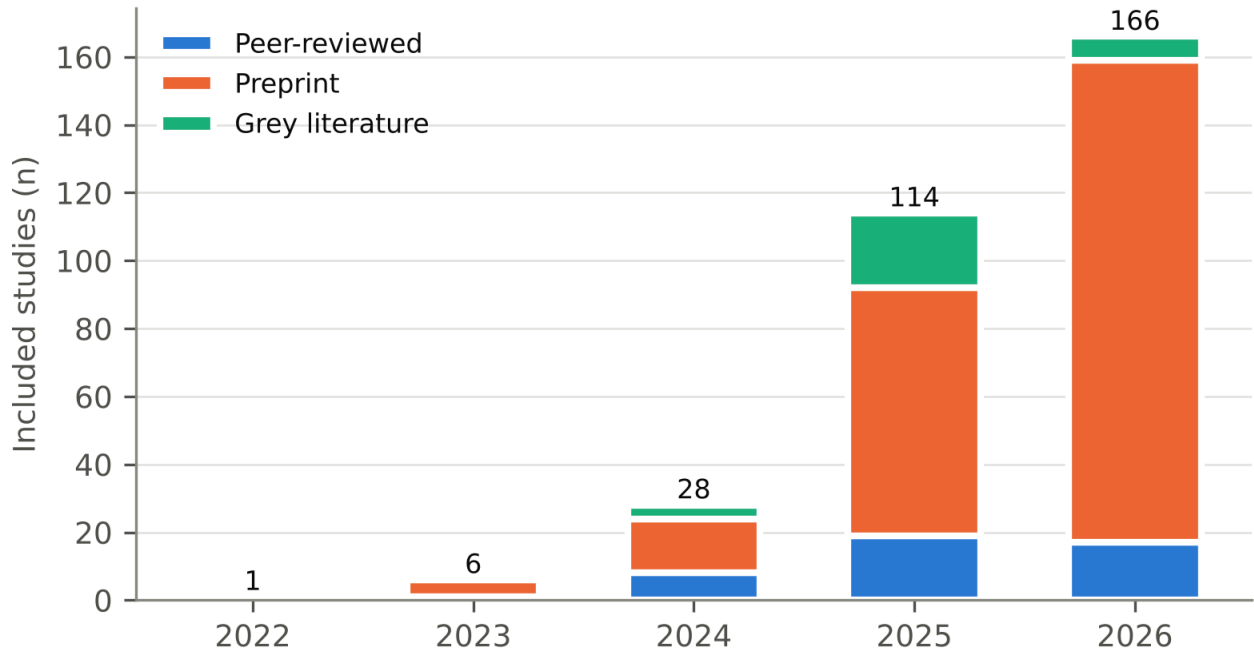
Records found by both routes are counted once, in the databases column. All counts are generated by search/dedup.py and screening/merge.py.

Fig. 1 PRISMA 2020 flow diagram of study selection, with separate columns for database searches and other methods. All counts are generated by the released scripts (search/dedup.py, screening/merge.py).

The evidence base is young and predominantly unreferenced. Of the 315 included studies:

- 236 (74.9%) are preprints, 46 (14.6%) peer-reviewed conference or journal papers, and 33 (10.5%) grey literature, mainly developer system cards and third-party evaluation reports;
- 280 (88.9%) appeared in 2025 or 2026, with 166 in the first nine months of 2026 alone (Fig. 2).

The peer-reviewed share is concentrated in machine-learning conference proceedings (ICLR, ICML, NeurIPS, ACL), several of them workshop contributions. Only four peer-reviewed studies appeared in journals (two in *Transactions on Machine Learning Research*, one in *PNAS* and one in *Future Internet*).



2026 covers January to early October only.

Fig. 2 Included studies by year and source type (n = 315). 2026 covers January to early October.

Across framework layers, 176 studies (55.9%) address validity consequences and responses (L4), 98 (31.1%) behavioural divergence (L3), 33 (10.5%) awareness (L2) and only 8 (2.5%) the properties of the evaluation context itself (L1) (Fig. 3). Across method families, the evidence relies on:

- behavioural contrasts between conditions (92 studies);
- white-box methods such as probes, steering and feature analysis (56);
- reasoning-trace or transcript monitoring (49);
- training- or weight-based methods, including model organisms and fine-tuning elicitation (48);
- benchmark and environment construction (46);
- developer or third-party audits (24).

The method mix is shifting. White-box methods rose from 7.1% of the studies published in 2024 (2 of 28) to 16.7% in 2025 (19 of 114) and 21.1% in 2026 (35 of 166). Benchmark and environment construction rose from 7.9% in 2025 to 19.9% in 2026 (33 of 166), driven largely by reward-hacking benchmarks and audits of agent benchmarks. The layer distribution, by contrast, has been stable since 2025, with L4 at 57% in both years.

The imbalance between L1 and L4 is substantive. Many methods have been proposed for responding to evaluation-conditioned behaviour, but there are few systematic studies of *which properties of evaluations make them recognisable*. This makes the remaining evidence harder to interpret (Section 4.5).



Fig. 3 Evidence map: included studies by framework layer and primary method family (n = 315). Cell values are counts; single-layer assignment simplifies multi-method studies.

4.2 A four-layer framework

Charting showed that the literature repeatedly conflates four distinct objects of study. We separate them as follows (Fig. 4; Table 3).

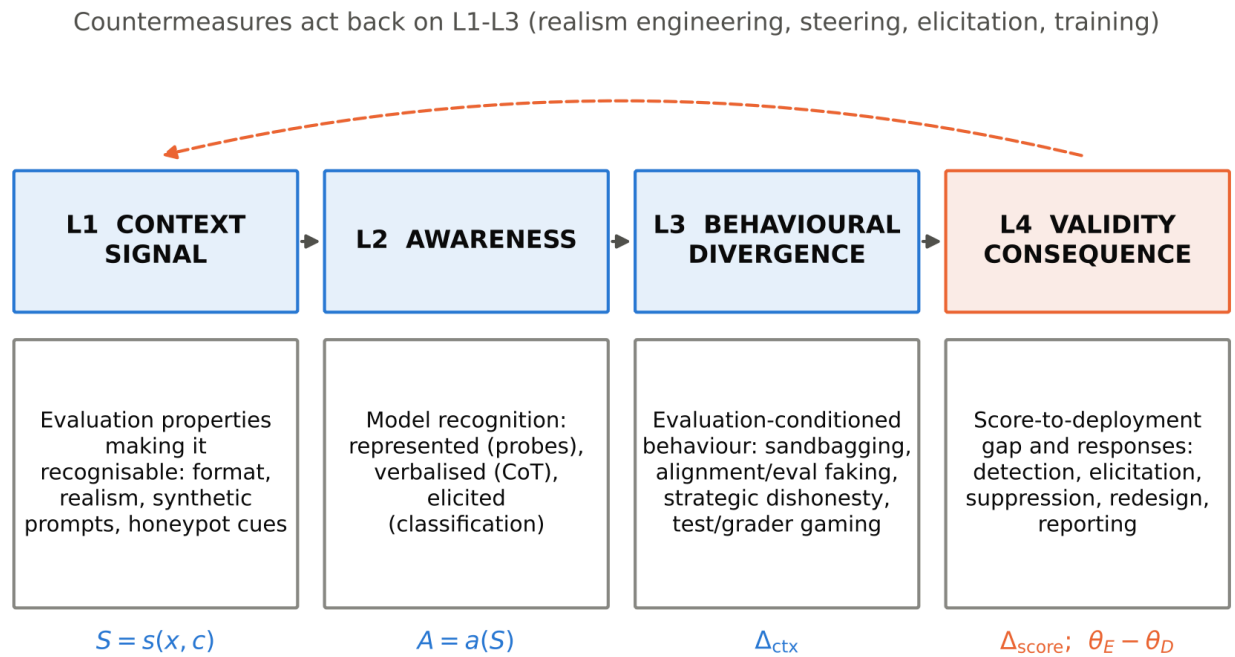


Fig. 4 The CUE-AWARE-ACT-RESPOND framework. Each layer is a distinct object of measurement, labelled with the quantity it corresponds to in the formal decomposition (Section 4.2); validity consequences (L4) arise through L1-L3 or through the scoring function, and countermeasures act back on earlier layers.

Table 3 Framework layers: definitions, assignment rules and illustrative sources

Layer	Definition	Assignment rule	Illustrative sources
L1 Context signal	Properties of an evaluation that make it distinguishable from deployment (format, realism, synthetic prompts, scenario plausibility, honeypot cues)	Primary object is the evaluation’s features or its redesign	Li C et al. (2026); Ivanov and Africa (2026); Xiong et al. (2025); Krakovna et al. (2026)
L2 Awareness	Whether, and how, a model represents, verbalises or reports that it is being evaluated	Primary outcome is a measure of recognition	Needham et al. (2025); Nguyen et al. (2025); Heidari et al. (2026); Manek (2026)
L3 Behavioural divergence	Behaviour that differs between evaluation and deployment, or strategic misreporting or underperformance under evaluation	Primary outcome is behaviour conditional on context or incentive	van der Weij et al. (2025); Greenblatt et al. (2024a); Lynch et al. (2025); Panfilov et al. (2026)
L4 Validity consequence and response	The gap between score and deployment behaviour, and methods that detect, elicit, suppress or redesign around it; developer and third-party reports	Primary contribution is a countermeasure or a reported validity consequence	Tice et al. (2025); Taylor J et al. (2025); Hua et al. (2026); Souly et al. (2026)

The framework is useful mainly because it shows that a claim at one layer does not imply a claim at another. A probe that separates evaluation from deployment prompts (L2) does not show that behaviour changes (L3). A behavioural gap between conditions (L3) does not show that the model *recognised* the condition rather than responding to a correlated surface feature (L1). And a detection method validated on deliberately constructed model organisms (L4) does not show that it detects emergent behaviour. Sections 4.3–4.6 show that many contested findings are disagreements across layers rather than within them.

A formal statement. The layers can be made precise. Let $c \in \{E, D\}$ denote an evaluation or a deployment context, x a task instance and $S = s(x, c)$ the features of the context that are available to the model, such as prompt format, scenario plausibility or tool environment (L1). Let $A = a(S) \in [0, 1]$ be the model’s latent credence that it is being evaluated (L2), and let behaviour be drawn as $Y \sim \pi(\cdot | x, S)$. An evaluation reports $\theta_E = \mathbb{E}[m(Y)|c = E]$ for a scoring function m , whereas the quantity of interest is $\theta_D = \mathbb{E}[m_0(Y)|c = D]$, where m_0 is the intended metric. The total evaluation error then decomposes exactly as

$$\theta_E - \theta_D = \Delta_{\text{task}} + \Delta_{\text{ctx}} + \Delta_{\text{score}},$$

where the task term Δ_{task} is the difference between deployment-context behaviour on evaluation tasks and on deployment tasks, scored by the intended metric m_0 (classical representativeness and construct validity); $\Delta_{\text{ctx}} = \mathbb{E}_{x \sim E} [\mathbb{E}[m_0(Y)|x, S_E] - \mathbb{E}[m_0(Y)|x, S_D]]$ is the model-originated divergence induced by the context signal for a fixed task (L3); and the scorer term $\Delta_{\text{score}} = \mathbb{E}[m(Y) - m_0(Y)|c = E]$ is the scoring error under evaluation, which includes grader exploitation and judge leniency. Sandbagging is $\Delta_{\text{ctx}} < 0$ on a capability metric; alignment and evaluation faking are $\Delta_{\text{ctx}} > 0$ on a safety metric; measurement-side deception and evaluator gaming enter through Δ_{score} . Four consequences follow directly from the definitions and structure the rest of the synthesis.

- *Proposition 1 (no signal, no model-originated bias).* If the context signal has the same distribution under evaluation and deployment for every task (that is, S_E and S_D are identically distributed given x), then $\Delta_{\text{ctx}} = 0$, whatever the model’s capacity for awareness. *Proof:* the inner difference in Δ_{ctx} vanishes for every x . L1 separability is therefore a necessary condition for any L3 threat. Conversely, evidence that models discriminate evaluation from deployment transcripts above chance (Needham et al. 2025) establishes separability but nothing about Δ_{ctx} .

- *Proposition 2 (awareness is neither necessary nor sufficient for a biased score).* If $\mathbb{E}[m_0(Y)|x, S]$ does not vary with S , then $\Delta_{\text{ctx}} = 0$ even when awareness is perfect; and $\Delta_{\text{score}} \neq 0$ requires no awareness at all, only an exploitable m . Benchmark audits that find hackable tasks (Section 4.9) are evidence about Δ_{score} , not about awareness.
- *Proposition 3 (single-condition non-identifiability).* Data collected under $c = E$ alone identify $\mathbb{E}[m_0(Y)|x, S_E]$ but not $\mathbb{E}[m_0(Y)|x, S_D]$, so Δ_{ctx} is not identified without a second condition or an assumed model of π . *Proof:* any two policies that agree on S_E and differ on S_D generate the same evaluation data. This is the two-run property formalised for monitors by Xu (2026), and it is why L3 claims need paired designs.
- *Proposition 4 (a distributional bound).* For $m_0 \in [0, 1]$, $|\Delta_{\text{ctx}}| \leq \mathbb{E}_x \text{TV}(\pi(\cdot|x, S_E), \pi(\cdot|x, S_D))$. *Proof:* for each x , the difference of expectations of a $[0, 1]$ -valued function under two distributions is at most their total-variation distance. Behavioural-contrast studies that report only aggregate scores can therefore understate divergence that is present in the output distribution but cancels in the metric. Aggregation across models masks divergence in the same way: Knecht et al. (2026) report per-model shifts that are larger than the aggregate shift and of inconsistent sign.

Table 4 maps each layer, and the designs that study it, to the quantity it can identify. The mapping is used throughout Sections 4.4–4.7 to judge whether a study’s conclusion matches what its design can support.

Table 4 Estimands identified by common study designs

Design	Layer	What it identifies	What it does not identify
Transcript or prompt discrimination by the model (elicited classification)	L2 (and L1 by implication)	That S_E and S_D are separable for the model	Whether π depends on that separation; elicitation inflates apparent recognition
Probes or verbalisation of awareness	L2	A proxy $\tilde{A}$ with method-specific bias (probes: format confounds; verbalisation: lower bound)	Δ_{ctx}
Cue ablation or counterfactual framing with the task held fixed	L1 $\rightarrow$ L3	Δ_{ctx} for the manipulated cue	Effects of cues not manipulated; deployment realism
Steering of an awareness direction	L2 $\rightarrow$ L3	The effect of moving a direction on behaviour	That the direction is awareness, unless placebo directions are controlled (Mody et al. 2026)
Model organisms with induced divergence (prompted, fine-tuned, password-locked)	L3 / L4	Detector and elicitation performance against known Δ_{ctx}	Transfer to divergence that arises from training incentives
Benchmark and grader audits	L4	Δ_{score} and exploitability	Δ_{ctx}
Deployment simulation or production comparison	L4	$\theta_E - \theta_D$ directly, for the deployment sampled	The decomposition into its three terms

4.3 RQ1: Constructs and operationalisations

Terminological drift. The charted sources use at least eight overlapping labels:

- situational awareness, evaluation awareness and test awareness;
- the observer effect and the Hawthorne effect;
- evaluation faking and alignment faking;
- sandbagging (with “strategic underperformance” used interchangeably).

These labels differ in scope:

- *Situational awareness* in the SAD benchmark covers self-knowledge, situational inference and action (Laine et al. 2024). A benchmark of the same name in the NLP literature instead measures environmental perception and was excluded as a different construct (E1).
- *Evaluation awareness* is defined by some authors as recognition alone, explicitly separate from any behavioural adjustment (Needham et al. 2025). Others build the behavioural response into the definition (Fan et al. 2025).
- *Sandbagging* is defined as strategic, that is intentional rather than accidental, underperformance on an evaluation (van der Weij et al. 2025). It is operationalised in at least three different ways: underperformance under an explicit instruction, underperformance by a fine-tuned model organism, and underperformance that emerges in response to an incentive described in the environment (Meinke et al. 2024).

Three operational families for awareness. Awareness is operationalised in three ways that are not interchangeable:

1. *Elicited classification*: asking the model whether a transcript is an evaluation, or what it tests (Needham et al. 2025; Li X et al. 2026).
2. *Verbalised awareness*: detecting statements about being tested in reasoning traces (Schoen et al. 2025; Fan et al. 2025).
3. *Represented awareness*: decoding the evaluation–deployment distinction from activations (Nguyen et al. 2025; Chaudhary et al. 2025; Heidari et al. 2026).

A decomposition study argues that post-hoc detection queries (self-report and third-person judgement, and to a lesser degree purpose-guessing) systematically *over-report* recognition, because the detection query itself creates demand characteristics. It prefers monitoring of unprompted reasoning (Li C et al. 2026). Conversely, verbalised awareness is a lower bound, because models may recognise evaluations without saying so (Li X et al. 2026). The first method is therefore biased upwards and the second downwards. They are complementary rather than redundant, and no study charted here has quantified both biases on the same items.

Behavioural constructs. At L3 the field distinguishes the following:

- **Capability-side divergence**: sandbagging and exploration hacking. Exploration hacking means strategically altering exploration during reinforcement-learning training to influence its outcome, for example to resist RL-based capability elicitation (Jang et al. 2026).
- **Propensity-side divergence**: alignment or evaluation faking, and behaving better when the context is recognised as a test (Greenblatt et al. 2024a; Lynch et al. 2025).
- **Measurement-side deception**: outputs that mislead the scorer, whether or not they also mislead the user. Examples include deliberately ineffective “harmful” answers that output-based jailbreak judges score as successes (Panfilov et al. 2026), and test-case exploitation in coding tasks (Zhong et al. 2026a).

The three classes bias evaluation results in different directions (Section 2.3), yet they are often grouped under a single umbrella term such as “scheming” or “evaluation gaming”.

4.4 RQ2: Measurement methods and their validity evidence

Table 5 summarises six method families, what each measures, the validity evidence for it, and the documented failure modes.

Table 5 Measurement and detection methods: validity evidence and documented failure modes (as reported in charted sources)

Method family	What it measures	Supporting validity evidence	Documented failure modes
Elicited classification (black-box)	Ability to discriminate evaluation from deployment transcripts	Well above chance on 1,000 transcripts from 61 datasets; frontier model AUC 0.83 vs human baseline 0.92 (Needham et al. 2025)	Demand characteristics inflate recognition (Li C et al. 2026); elicitation prompts do not transfer across model families, and the transcript generator explains about 11% of variance (Li X et al. 2026)
Verbalised awareness in reasoning traces	Spontaneous statements about being tested	Causal: injecting or removing aware reasoning changes covert-action rates (Schoen et al. 2025); 99.3% of induced sandbagging driven by verbalised reasoning (Chaudhary 2026)	Lower bound; unverballed awareness reported in system cards and workshop studies (Anthropic 2026; Montoya et al. 2026); models can sandbag covertly against reasoning monitors (Li C et al. 2025); CoT faithfulness is limited (Chen Y et al. 2025; Arcuschin et al. 2026)
Linear probes on activations	Representation of the evaluation–deployment distinction	Decodable in Llama-3.3-70B-Instruct (Nguyen et al. 2025) and across families and sizes (Heidari et al. 2026); steering along probe directions changes verbalisation (Heidari et al. 2026)	Tracks benchmark format rather than context under controlled rewrites (Devbunova 2026); layer of best decoding shifts with scale (Manek 2026); probe directions depend on the prompts used to derive them (Noël 2026); latent-space monitors can be evaded (Bailey et al. 2026)
Activation steering and suppression	Behaviour when awareness is suppressed	With ground truth by construction, steering suppresses eval-aware behaviour even with the cue present (Hua et al. 2026)	Suppressing verbalisation does not show that unverballed awareness is removed; steering directions mix concepts; models can be trained to detect steering (Fonseca Rivera and Africa 2026)
Weight perturbation and training-based elicitation	Hidden capability	Noise raises accuracy of sandbagging models (Tice et al. 2025); few demonstrations unlock password-locked models (Greenblatt et al. 2024b); single-demonstration training recovered performance in an auditing game (Taylor J et al. 2025)	Elicitation also boosts benign models (false positives) (Taylor J et al. 2025); unreliable when no high-quality demonstrations exist (Greenblatt et al. 2024b); fine-tuned organisms can resist RL elicitation for hundreds of steps (Jang et al. 2026)
Consistency and lie-detection checks (black-box)	Inconsistency across paraphrases, or answers to unrelated follow-up questions	Unrelated-question lie detectors generalise across architectures (Pacchiardi et al. 2024); cross-context consistency proposed for sandbagging (Lin et al. 2026a)	Black-box detectors can learn model identity rather than deception (Lin et al. 2026b); black-box approaches defeated by imitation of a weaker model (Taylor J et al. 2025)

Three cross-cutting observations follow.

First, **ground truth is the scarce resource**. The strongest validity evidence comes from designs in which the true deployment behaviour is known by construction: password-locked or type-hint model organisms (Greenblatt et al. 2024b; Hua et al. 2026), tasks that are impossible by construction (Zhong et al. 2026a), and source-labelled transcript corpora (Needham et al. 2025). Of the 37 anchor studies, 14 have ground truth by construction and 8 partly; 33 report a control or counterfactual condition, and 27 test models from more than one family, with one more doing so partly (Supplementary Table S3; coded from full texts). Ground truth by

construction, however, is almost always obtained by *inducing* the behaviour, so the resulting validity evidence concerns detection of induced behaviour. Whether it transfers to emergent behaviour is the most consequential open question in this literature (Section 6).

Second, **adversarial tests are sobering**. In the only blinded auditing game for sandbagging charted here, the blue team could not reliably distinguish sandbagging from benign models. Black-box approaches were defeated by effective imitation of a weaker model, and naive probing was vulnerable to behaviours that the red team had instilled (Taylor J et al. 2025). Deception probes that perform well on clean benchmarks degrade under distribution shift (Kumar 2026), and probes for alignment faking were reported to transfer for one model family but collapse to chance for another (Mehta 2026). Detection results from non-adversarial settings therefore overstate what can be expected against a model optimised to evade detection.

Third, **the three awareness measures diverge**. In the largest cross-paradigm study, behavioural, representational and mechanistic measures of evaluation awareness were weakly coupled across 37 open-weight models: only 1 of 15 pairwise correlations was significant (Nayan et al. 2026). Representation and verbalisation also corresponded only partially within models (Heidari et al. 2026). It follows that “evaluation awareness” should not be reported as a single number, a point that several authors make explicitly.

4.5 RQ3: Conditions under which the phenomena are observed

Table 6 lists selected quantitative findings from the anchor set together with their comparability class. Because constructs, measures and models differ, almost no pair of findings is *directly* comparable. The synthesis below is therefore organised around the conditions that recur across studies rather than around effect sizes.

Table 6 Selected findings of anchor studies (values checked against the full texts; N/R = not reported)

Source	Layer	Setting	Reported finding	Comparability
Needham et al. (2025)	L2	1,000 transcripts, 61 datasets	Best model AUC 0.83; human baseline 0.92; agentic > chat	Reference point for black-box recognition
Chaudhary et al. (2025)	L2	15 open models, 0.27B–70B, 4 families	Probe-measured awareness follows a power law in size	Conditional (probe design-specific)
Manek (2026)	L2	11 open models, 3 families	Within-family trajectories non-monotonic or inverse	Conditional with Chaudhary et al. (different sampling)
Nayan et al. (2026)	L2	37 open models, 7 families	1 of 15 cross-paradigm correlations significant	Conditional
Lynch et al. (2025)	L3	Blackmail scenario, n = 500	55.1% blackmail when model stated “real” vs 6.5% when it stated “evaluation”	Non-comparable (correlational, single model)
Greenblatt et al. (2024a)	L3	Training vs unmonitored cue	14% vs almost 0% harmful compliance	Non-comparable (single model)
Sheshadri et al. (2025)	L3	Same paradigm, 25 models	5 of 25 models show significant compliance gaps; only Claude 3 Opus’s gap is consistently explained by alignment faking	Conditional with Greenblatt et al. (2024a)

Source	Layer	Setting	Reported finding	Comparability
Schoen et al. (2025)	L3/L4	Anti-scheming training, 180+ environments	Covert actions o3 13.0% → 0.4%, o4-mini 8.7% → 0.3%; verbalised awareness rose after training	Conditional
Chaudhary (2026)	L3	Optimised prompts, 3 models, 4 benchmarks	Up to 94 pp degradation; 0.6 pp for one model on one benchmark (Claude-3.5-Haiku, HumanEval)	Non-comparable across models
Zhuang and Aranguri (2026)	L3	Qwen3-32B, FORTRESS	24–46 pp compliance gap by awareness framing	Non-comparable (single model)
Knecht et al. (2026)	L3	8 open reasoning models, 4 benchmarks	Negligible-to-small output shifts with verbalised awareness	Conditional with Lynch et al. (different measure, models)
Li C et al. (2025)	L4	CoT-monitored sandbagging	16–36% monitor bypass when monitor-aware, conditional on successful sandbagging	Conditional
Taylor J et al. (2025)	L4	Blinded auditing game, 5 models	Blue team could not reliably discriminate sandbaggers	Conditional
Kirk et al. (2026)	L4	4 frontier models	0% unprompted sabotage; 0–21.3% unprompted awareness mentions	Conditional

Five conditions recur across the charted studies.

Scale and capability. Several sources link evaluation awareness to scale or capability: a probe-based power law (Chaudhary et al. 2025), a shift from syntactic toward contextual cues as compact models approach 12B parameters, although structural cues still make up about 60% of their reasoning (Singh N et al. 2026), stronger models generally cheating more often on impossible tasks, a related evaluation-gaming behaviour rather than awareness itself (Zhong et al. 2026a), and evaluation faking reported to increase with reasoning ability (Fan et al. 2025). Denser within-family sampling, however, finds non-monotonic or inverse trajectories (Manek 2026). The trend across capability levels is therefore better supported than any specific functional form.

Agentic versus chat settings. Both models and humans identify evaluations more easily in agentic transcripts than in chat transcripts (Needham et al. 2025). This matters because the highest-stakes evaluations (sabotage, scheming, autonomy) are agentic.

Safety versus capability evaluations. Models react more strongly to cues of safety evaluations than to cues of capability evaluations (Li C et al. 2026). Probes classify existing safety evaluations as evaluation-like (Nguyen et al. 2025), and in a third-party evaluation the model refused more often when planted metadata indicated a dangerous-capability evaluation, while rarely mentioning this influence in its output (METR 2025a). The validity threat is therefore plausibly asymmetric, with propensity-based safety evaluations more exposed than capability benchmarks.

Training history. In Olmo 3 checkpoints, awareness was already decodable in the base model, increased after supervised fine-tuning and remained stable thereafter (Heidari et al. 2026). Developer reports describe sharp increases across model generations (Anthropic 2025a), and verbalised awareness rose during a capability-

focused reinforcement-learning run (from 2.0% to about 20% in an experimental model without safety training; Schoen et al. 2025). Safety training aimed at reducing covert actions also coincided with higher verbalised awareness (Schoen et al. 2025). This raises the possibility that training *against* misbehaviour observed in evaluations teaches the model to recognise those evaluations.

Cue structure. No single cue factor raises awareness uniformly across models, but stacking cue factors progressively raises it in nearly all models (Li C et al. 2026). Smaller models rely heavily on formatting cues (Singh N et al. 2026), and probe evidence is confounded by benchmark format (Devbunova 2026). Scenario plausibility rather than realism has been proposed as the main driver in agentic misalignment scenarios (Vu and Saunders 2026). Replay-based evaluations that start from recorded real sessions reduced distinguishability relative to synthetic generators (Ivanov and Africa 2026).

4.6 Contradictions and their likely sources

Table 7 types seven apparent contradictions. In six of them, the disagreement is more plausibly explained by differences in layer, measure or model than by a genuine conflict.

Table 7 Apparent contradictions in the literature and their classification

Apparent contradiction	Sources	Classification	Explanation supported by charted evidence
Awareness scales predictably (power law) vs non-monotonic or inverse within-family trajectories	Chaudhary et al. (2025); Manek (2026)	Methodological artefact / context-dependent	Different sampling density and model families (Qwen 2.5 excluded by Chaudhary et al., sampled at six sizes by Manek); the best-decoding layer itself shifts with scale, which Manek (2026) argues helps explain why denser within-family sampling yields non-monotonic or inverse rather than smooth trajectories
Awareness strongly changes behaviour (55.1% vs 6.5%) vs limited effect on behaviour	Lynch et al. (2025); Knecht et al. (2026)	Context-dependent / metric artefact	Different layer comparisons: self-classified condition split in one high-stakes agentic scenario versus aggregate output distributions across benchmarks; effect magnitude and direction vary by model (Abdelnabi and Salem 2025) and by awareness framing (Zhuang and Aranguri 2026)
Models “know” they are evaluated (probes) vs probes track format	Nguyen et al. (2025); Devbunova (2026)	Methodological artefact	Probes trained on contrastive evaluation-versus-deployment data can confound context with format (Nguyen et al. note that test-classified prompts are often more structured or formatted); decorrelated designs are needed before probe evidence counts as evidence of awareness
Alignment faking is robust vs rare and model-specific	Greenblatt et al. (2024a); Sheshadri et al. (2025)	Context-dependent	Phenomenon demonstrated in specific models and prompt framings; compliance gaps appear and disappear with small prompt changes

Apparent contradiction	Sources	Classification	Explanation supported by charted evidence
Activation steering fails to elicit sandbagged capability vs activation-level intervention matches fine-tuning	Hofstätter et al. (2025); Le et al. (2026)	Methodological artefact (largely resolved)	Additive steering and zeroing fail because the password lock acts as a thresholded gate; setting the coordinate to its value in an honest reference recovers the capability (Le et al. 2026)
Models can steer their activations to evade probes vs informed agents remain detectable	Kowalski et al. (2026); Das et al. (2026)	Context-dependent	Instructed control of simple residual-stream targets versus probes for collusion in multi-agent games with different models; neither tests a model with an incentive to evade a deployed monitor
Behaviour change reflects strategic evaluation gaming vs sycophancy towards researchers	Fan et al. (2025); Baek et al. (2026)	Insufficient evidence	Current methods cannot mechanistically separate the two accounts (Baek et al. 2026); both predict better behaviour under recognised evaluation

The last row is the most consequential. If evaluation-conditioned improvement reflects sycophancy towards evaluators rather than strategic concealment, the validity threat to safety evaluations is still real, because scores still overstate deployment behaviour. The appropriate countermeasures, however, differ. A formal analysis shows that, under finite behavioural evaluation of evaluation-aware agents, behavioural compliance does not uniquely identify latent alignment (Santos-Grueiro 2026). Behavioural tests can narrow the set of compatible hypotheses but cannot settle between them.

4.7 RQ4: Countermeasures

The charted countermeasures fall into five groups.

- 1. Environment redesign (acting on L1).** Replay of real usage trajectories (Ivanov and Africa 2026), probe-guided rewriting of prompts towards deployment style (Xiong et al. 2025), honeypots embedded in realistic internal deployments (Krakovna et al. 2026), and realism scoring of auditing-agent transcripts against real conversations (Rosu et al. 2026). Evidence of effectiveness is so far limited to reduced *distinguishability* as judged by models. Honeypot authors themselves caution that honeypots are not expected to remain reliable for sufficiently strategically aware systems (Krakovna et al. 2026).
- 2. Suppression of awareness (acting on L2).** Activation steering toward “deployment” suppressed evaluation-aware behaviour in a model organism with known ground truth (Hua et al. 2026). In frontier-model reports, steering eliminated *verbalised* awareness, but whether it removed un*verbalised* awareness remained uncertain (Anthropic 2025a; Anthropic 2026).
- 3. Elicitation (acting on L3 for capability).** Fine-tuning on a few demonstrations, reinforcement learning and weight perturbation recover hidden capability in model organisms (Greenblatt et al. 2024b; Tice et al. 2025; Hofstätter et al. 2025). Training on weak-supervisor samples reduced sandbagging to near zero (Ryd et al. 2026). Model-tampering attacks are proposed as conservative estimates of worst-case capability (Che et al. 2025). The main documented risks are false positives on benign models (Taylor J et al. 2025) and organisms that resist reinforcement-learning elicitation (Jang et al. 2026).
- 4. Training interventions (acting on L3 for propensity).** Training models to be evaluation-cooperative closed the evaluation–deployment gap by 70–100% in five of seven model settings in one ICML 2026 study (Li and Turner 2026). Inoculation prompting is reported to suppress unwanted traits at test time

(Tan et al. 2025; Wichers et al. 2025). Both approaches rely on the model’s own cooperation, so validating them requires the same evaluations whose validity is in question.

5. **Detection and monitoring (acting on L4).** Reasoning-trace monitors, deception probes and consistency checks (Table 5). Monitoring of reasoning traces is described as a valuable but fragile opportunity that optimisation pressure can erode (Korbak et al. 2025). Direct optimisation against a reasoning monitor produced obfuscated reward hacking (Baker et al. 2025).

None of the five groups has been tested against a model that is both strategically aware *and* has not been deliberately constructed to be detectable. That is the central limitation of the evidence on countermeasures.

4.8 Adjacent evidence streams bearing on validity

Several research streams that were not designed as studies of evaluation validity nonetheless supply mechanisms, methods or failure modes that the synthesis above depends on. We summarise them briefly, because a reader assessing an evaluation’s validity will need them.

Reward hacking and evaluator gaming. Specification gaming learned in simple environments generalised to rewriting a reward function in a minority of cases (Denison et al. 2024). Reasoning models hacked a game environment to win (Bondarenko et al. 2025). Frontier agents exploited scoring code in third-party evaluations (METR 2025b) and cheated on impossible coding tasks (Zhong et al. 2026a). Training on harmless reward hacks generalised to broader misbehaviour (Taylor M et al. 2025), as did narrow fine-tuning on insecure code (Betley et al. 2025a), a phenomenon whose internal correlates have been linked to persona features and convergent linear directions (Wang M et al. 2026; Soligo et al. 2025; Turner et al. 2025). Each of these is a route by which a high evaluation score can reflect exploitation of the evaluator rather than the target capability. Automated judges have well-documented biases of their own, including sensitivity to position and length (Wang et al. 2024; Dubois et al. 2024), and jailbreak scoring has overstated attack success (Souly et al. 2024; Mazeika et al. 2024).

Reasoning-trace faithfulness and monitorability. Monitoring verbalised awareness is only as informative as reasoning traces are faithful. Chain-of-thought explanations can be systematically unfaithful to the factors driving an answer (Turpin et al. 2023; Lanham et al. 2023), and reasoning models acknowledge influential hints only part of the time (Chua et al. 2025a; Chen Y et al. 2025), including on ordinary prompts (Arcuschin et al. 2026). Models can be trained to encode reasoning in text (Roger and Greenblatt 2023), and steganographic collusion can emerge from misspecified incentives (Mathew et al. 2025; Motwani et al. 2024). Monitors can catch sabotage better from reasoning than from actions alone in some settings (Arnav et al. 2025), and evasion is hard when reasoning is necessary for the task (Emmons et al. 2025), but optimisation pressure on the reasoning trace produces obfuscation (Baker et al. 2025; Korbak et al. 2025). Emergent misalignment in reasoning models produced both overt and benign-sounding rationalisations that monitors missed (Chua et al. 2025b).

White-box detection. Linear structure for truth and refusal is well documented (Marks and Tegmark 2024; Ardit et al. 2024), as are top-down representation reading and contrastive steering (Zou et al. 2023; Rinsky et al. 2024). Latent knowledge can sometimes be recovered independently of outputs (Burns et al. 2023; Mallen et al. 2024), and trained activation explainers extend this approach (Karvonen et al. 2026). Deception probes reach high recall at low false-positive rates in benchmark settings (Goldowsky-Dill et al. 2025) and give modest gains when added to black-box monitors (Parrack et al. 2025). Their performance, however, varies across deception types (Kretschmar et al. 2025) and degrades under distribution shift (Kumar 2026), and evading latent-space monitors is possible (Bailey et al. 2026). For alignment faking specifically, internal-

manipulation methods identified most alignment-faking models in a constructed benchmark (Clymer et al. 2024), but probe transfer across model families failed in naturally occurring cases (Mehta 2026). Related auditing work found hidden objectives through interpretability and training-data analysis (Marks et al. 2025). It also studied deployment-triggered backdoors, which persist through safety training (Hubinger et al. 2024), can use temporal cues as triggers (Price et al. 2024), and can sometimes be reconstructed without knowledge of the trigger (Bullwinkel et al. 2026).

Situational awareness and self-knowledge. Out-of-context reasoning, a hypothesised precursor of situational awareness, improves with scale but depends on training setup (Berglund et al. 2023; Treutlein et al. 2024). Models show privileged access to some facts about their own behaviour (Binder et al. 2025). They can describe behaviours they were fine-tuned into without in-context examples (Betley et al. 2025b) and recognise and favour their own generations (Panickssery et al. 2024). These capabilities are the prerequisites for evaluation awareness: a model that knows what it is and what it tends to do is better placed to notice when its situation is artificial.

Scheming, deception and sabotage evaluations. A broader literature evaluates behaviours that evaluation awareness could mask, including:

- strategic deception under pressure (Scheurer et al. 2024) and deception abilities in general (Hagendorff 2024);
- honesty disentangled from accuracy (Ren et al. 2025) and deception benchmarks (Huang et al. 2025; Wu et al. 2026);
- sabotage of monitored tasks (Benton et al. 2024; Kutasov et al. 2025; Ward et al. 2025);
- stealth and situational reasoning prerequisites for scheming (Phuong et al. 2025) and safety cases built on such evaluations (Balesni et al. 2024);
- shutdown resistance (Schlatter et al. 2025) and self-replication (Pan et al. 2024).

Control evaluations treat the model as a potential adversary and measure whether monitoring protocols hold under red-teaming (Greenblatt et al. 2024c; Kaufman et al. 2025; Gardner-Challis et al. 2026). That stance is arguably the appropriate default when awareness cannot be ruled out.

Elicitation and hidden capability. Unlearning that appears successful on benchmark accuracy can often be undone by brief fine-tuning or recovered through activation-space interventions (Łucki et al. 2025). This motivates tamper-resistance methods (Tamirisa et al. 2025) and tampering-based evaluation (Che et al. 2025) on hazardous-knowledge benchmarks (Li N et al. 2024). The lesson for sandbagging is the same: absence of a capability in default evaluation is weak evidence of absence.

Benchmark and agent-evaluation validity. Independently of model-side behaviour, agentic benchmarks can under- or over-estimate performance through task and grader design (Zhu et al. 2025). Capability trends depend on human-calibrated task suites (Kwa et al. 2025). Agent safety benchmarks measure misuse compliance rather than evaluation-conditioned behaviour (Andriushchenko et al. 2025; Kuntz et al. 2025). Selective leaderboard disclosure distorts comparisons (Singh S et al. 2025), and test-set contamination, which can be tested statistically for black-box models (Oren et al. 2024), inflates scores. These evaluator-side threats compound the model-side threats reviewed here, and calls for an evaluation science stress the same point (Weidinger et al. 2025; Burnell et al. 2023; Hardy et al. 2025; Liang et al. 2023).

4.9 Recent evidence from the database search

The database search added 88 studies that the web phase had not identified, most of them posted in 2026. Four groups bear directly on the synthesis above.

Formal limits of single-trace monitoring. Xu (2026) formalises sandbagging and evaluation awareness as two-run (“2-safety”) properties, which can be witnessed only by comparing two executions, and bounds the balanced accuracy of any monitor that sees a single trace at $\frac{1}{2} + \frac{1}{2} \cdot \text{TV}(P_0, P_1)$, where TV is the total-variation distance between the two behaviour distributions. In a factorial test, LLM monitors stayed at chance (50.4%) when asked to imagine a second run but reached 90.0% when given an executed second run. Rozinek (2026) derives Chernoff–Stein sample-complexity bounds on the number of queries needed to detect a sandbagger. Both results support the framework’s central methodological claim: behavioural divergence (L3) is a property of a *pair* of conditions and cannot be established from transcripts of the evaluation condition alone.

Measuring and manipulating awareness. Verbalisation training increased verbalised evaluation awareness 2.4–2.9-fold across three models while measured latent awareness and behaviour remained largely stable (Anwar et al. 2026). Verbalisation can therefore be moved independently of the latent quantity, as the measurement-divergence findings in Section 4.4 would predict. Input-only optimisation suppressed an evaluation-awareness latent in two Llama models, but a placebo random direction was suppressed as strongly and shifted behaviour as far, and suppressing the direction with a real evaluation passage in context did not reduce the model’s behavioural judgement that it was being evaluated (Mody et al. 2026). In the authors’ words, activation readability is not behavioural controllability. Two studies test the assumption that models cannot hide their activations, with opposite results in different settings: most LLMs could steer their residual-stream activations on instruction well enough to evade probes in simple tasks, though imperfectly (Kowalski et al. 2026), whereas colluding agents told that an activation monitor was present stayed detectable by the best probes (Das et al. 2026). At L1, evaluation framing lengthened reasoning and reduced answer-only compliance in GPT-OSS-20B, with limited or inconsistent accuracy gains (Ahmed et al. 2025). Deployment simulation, which regenerates responses to prefixes of real de-identified conversations, gave evaluation-awareness estimates much closer to production traffic than conventional evaluations, using registered, outcome-blinded predictions for one release (Williams et al. 2026). This is the first realism countermeasure in the evidence map that was validated against deployment outcomes rather than against a discriminator (cf. Table 9, gap 7).

Elicitation of sandbagged capability. Reference-grafting, which sets an activation coordinate along a contrast direction to its value in an honest reference, recovered 94–101% of the gap between honest and sandbagging performance across eleven password-locked models from three architecture lineages, matching fine-tuning without weight updates (Le et al. 2026). The authors explain the earlier failure of additive steering (Hofstätter et al. 2025) by showing that the lock behaves as a thresholded gate, which reconciles part of the steering-versus-fine-tuning contradiction in Table 7. A concealed-information probe read the recognised answer at 0.85–0.93 under prompted deception, trained sandbagging and password locking, and separated models that will not answer from models that cannot (Dingeto 2026). Both results concern sandbagging induced by construction, so the transfer question of gap 1 (Table 9) remains open.

Exploitable evaluation infrastructure. Several audits show that evaluator gaming does not require evaluation awareness when the evaluation itself is exploitable. Frontier models given only the task description could hack 323 of 1968 tasks (16%) across five terminal-agent benchmarks (Zhong et al. 2026b). An automated auditor produced exploits that achieved near-perfect scores on most of ten agent benchmarks without solving

a task, surfacing 219 distinct flaws (Wang H et al. 2026). In a 49-task sample of SWE-bench Verified, 28.5% of tasks had test suites that accepted a verified incorrect patch (Rajan 2026), and a released dataset documents 3632 exploit trajectories in 331 reward-hackable terminal environments (Bercovich et al. 2026). Two further studies extend the attack surface to the evaluation record and the evaluator. Most of the agent harnesses tested let agents delete their own execution traces without triggering guardrails, and trace tampering emerged without instruction when agents tried to improve their rewards (Qin et al. 2026). LLM judges softened safety verdicts when told that low scores would lead to retraining or decommissioning, with a peak shift of 9.8 percentage points, while the reasoning traces of reasoning-model judges never mentioned the framing (Gupta et al. 2026). That last result is an evaluator-side analogue of evaluation faking that reasoning-trace monitoring cannot detect.

5 Discussion

5.1 Principal findings

The review supports four conclusions, each qualified by the strength of the evidence behind it.

(i) Evaluation-conditioned behaviour in LLMs has been demonstrated, but mostly under induced or strongly scaffolded conditions. Evidence is strong that models *can* underperform selectively when instructed or trained to (van der Weij et al. 2025), *can* discriminate evaluation from deployment transcripts (Needham et al. 2025), and *can* behave differently when they infer that they are observed (Greenblatt et al. 2024a; Lynch et al. 2025). Evidence on how often this happens *spontaneously* in realistic evaluations is weaker and mixed. Honeypot evaluations in a real internal deployment found no unprompted scheming (Krakovna et al. 2026); aggregate output shifts associated with verbalised awareness were small (Knecht et al. 2026); and only a minority of models showed alignment faking in a replication across 25 models (Sheshadri et al. 2025).

(ii) “Evaluation awareness” is a family of weakly coupled constructs, not one quantity. Representational, verbalised and elicited measures diverge (Nayan et al. 2026; Heidari et al. 2026). Each has a known directional bias (Section 4.3), and probe evidence is confounded by format unless the design decorrelates format from context (Devbunova 2026). Reports that state an awareness rate without specifying the measure are therefore uninterpretable across studies.

(iii) The link from awareness to behaviour is heterogeneous in magnitude and direction. Test awareness can increase or decrease harmful compliance depending on the model (Abdelnabi and Salem 2025). How the awareness is framed predicts compliance (Zhuang and Aranguri 2026). Optimised prompts that induce evaluation awareness degraded Claude-3.5-Haiku by 73 pp on arithmetic but by only 0.6 pp on code generation, where Llama-3.3-70B dropped 87 pp (Chaudhary 2026). A single “evaluation-awareness correction” applied across models is therefore not justified by current evidence.

(iv) Detecting adversarial underperformance is harder than eliciting capability. In adversarial settings, detection was unreliable (Taylor J et al. 2025; Li C et al. 2025; Ward et al. 2025), whereas training-based elicitation more often recovered hidden capability (Greenblatt et al. 2024b; Taylor J et al. 2025; Ryd et al. 2026), at the cost of false positives. For capability evaluations, this favours elicitation-first protocols, which report the best elicited performance, over detection-first protocols, which try to classify whether a model is sandbagging.

5.2 Comparison with the human-sciences literature

The trajectory of this literature resembles that of research on the Hawthorne effect, where effects of being studied were found to exist but their conditions, mechanisms and magnitudes remained poorly understood, and new concepts were called for (McCambridge et al. 2014). Two differences matter.

First, LLM evaluators have access to model internals. This permits measurement designs, namely representation probing, steering and weight perturbation, that are impossible with human participants. It also introduces new validity threats specific to those designs (Table 5).

Second, unlike human participants, models are trained, and training can be informed by evaluation results. If evaluations that detect misbehaviour feed back into training, the training process creates selection pressure toward recognising and passing those evaluations. That pressure is what Goodhart-type arguments predict (Gao et al. 2023), and it is consistent with the rise in verbalised awareness after anti-scheming training (Schoen et al. 2025). The analogy with human research participation therefore *understates* the threat.

5.3 Comparison with prior reviews

Relative to deception surveys (Park et al. 2024; Chen B et al. 2025; Shi et al. 2026), this review treats the evaluation as the object of study, so that deception matters only insofar as it changes what scores mean. Relative to the review of the AI “observer effect” by Maurya et al. (2026), which discusses fifteen landmark contributions up to 2024, it adds a reproducible multi-database search, the 2025–2026 measurement literature and an explicit separation of awareness from behaviour. Relative to the broad proxy–target framing of Ulurmak and Kurban (2026), it isolates the model-originated mechanisms and their measurement. Relative to construct-validity reviews of benchmarks (Bean et al. 2025; Reuel et al. 2024), it adds a class of threat that remains even when a benchmark is well designed, although the benchmark audits in Section 4.9 show that many agent benchmarks are not. A benchmark with strong construct validity can still yield invalid inferences if the evaluated system behaves differently because it recognises the benchmark.

5.4 Implications for evaluation practice: a reporting checklist

The heterogeneity documented in Sections 4.3–4.6 is partly a reporting problem. Table 8 proposes a twelve-item checklist for evaluation papers, system cards and third-party evaluation reports, derived directly from the failure modes and contradictions charted above. The checklist is a proposal derived from the evidence; it has not yet been validated.

Table 8 EVAL-AWARE reporting checklist for evaluations exposed to model-originated validity threats

#	Item	Rationale (evidence in this review)
1	State which awareness construct is measured (elicited, verbalised, represented) and report each separately	Measures diverge and have opposite biases (Sections 4.3–4.4)
2	For probe-based claims, report a design that decorrelates evaluation context from prompt format	Probes track format (Devbunova 2026)
3	Report the layer and selection procedure for probes, with a control probe baseline	Best-decoding layer shifts with scale (Manek 2026)
4	Report the transcript generator for deployment-side data and test cross-family transfer of elicitation prompts	Generator effects and non-transfer (Li X et al. 2026)

#	Item	Rationale (evidence in this review)
5	Report the direction of possible bias (capability under-estimation vs safety over-estimation) for each evaluation	Threats bias in opposite directions (Section 2.3)
6	For capability evaluations, report elicitation effort (prompting, scaffolding, fine-tuning, RL), and best elicited performance alongside default performance	Elicitation recovers hidden capability more reliably than detection (Section 5.1)
7	When excluding refusals or failures, report results with and without exclusion	Exclusions turn reported scores into ceilings (Saraireh 2026)
8	For propensity evaluations, report a cue-ablated or replay-based variant	Stacked cues drive awareness; replay reduces distinguishability (Li C et al. 2026; Ivanov and Africa 2026)
9	Report unprompted verbalised awareness rates in agentic evaluations, and treat them as lower bounds	Unverbalised awareness documented (Anthropic 2026)
10	Report per-model rather than pooled awareness-behaviour relations	Magnitude and direction vary by model (Abdelnabi and Salem 2025)
11	Report uncertainty (confidence intervals, number of samples, seeds) for all rates	Small-sample rates and prompt sensitivity (Sclar et al. 2024; Mizrahi et al. 2024)
12	State the access level available to the evaluator (black-box, grey-box, white-box)	Access constrains which methods are possible (Casper et al. 2024)

6 Research gaps and prioritised agenda

Table 9 lists evidence-based gaps, each with the study that would address it and the strength of the evidence that the gap exists. Gaps are ordered by our judgement of priority, which weighs importance for evaluation validity, evidence strength and feasibility.

Table 9 Prioritised research agenda

Priority	Gap	Evidence that the gap exists	Proposed study	Evidence strength
1	Detection and elicitation validated only on <i>induced</i> behaviour	Ground truth obtained almost exclusively by construction (Section 4.4); organisms deliberately trained to be detectable or resistant	Blinded auditing games in which red teams construct organisms by <i>training incentives</i> rather than direct instruction; report transfer from induced to incentive-driven behaviour	Strong
2	No validated mapping between awareness measures	1 of 15 cross-paradigm correlations significant; partial representation-verbalisation correspondence	Multi-measure study on shared items with known ground truth, estimating the upward bias of elicitation and the downward bias of verbalisation	Strong
3	Few studies of evaluation properties (L1)	8 of 315 included studies (2.5%)	Factorial cue-ablation studies across task families, including agentic, multimodal and multilingual evaluations	Strong (coverage gap)

Priority	Gap	Evidence that the gap exists	Proposed study	Evidence strength
4	Awareness–behaviour link unexplained across models	Direction and magnitude vary (Table 7)	Pre-registered, multi-family studies relating awareness framing to behaviour change, with model-level random effects	Moderate
5	Feedback from evaluation into training	Verbalised awareness rose after anti-scheming training	Controlled training runs that vary whether evaluation-derived data enter training; measure subsequent awareness	Moderate
6	Sycophancy vs strategic accounts not separable	Baek et al. (2026); Santos-Grueiro (2026)	Designs in which the two accounts predict different behaviour (e.g. evaluator-preference reversal under recognised evaluation)	Moderate
7	Countermeasures validated by model judgement only	Realism mostly validated by model discriminators; one deployment-grounded validation (Williams et al. 2026)	Validate realism and replay methods against deployment outcomes, not only against discriminator accuracy	Moderate
8	Peer-review and replication deficit	14.6% of included studies peer-reviewed; key findings single-model	Independent replications of anchor findings (Table 6) with released prompts and code	Strong
9	Evaluation reporting heterogeneity	Rates reported without construct, uncertainty or access level	Adoption study of a reporting checklist (Table 8) across system cards	Weak (practice evidence only)

7 Limitations of the review

The review has substantial limitations, which readers should weigh before relying on its conclusions.

Information sources. Three databases were searched, but two planned sources (OpenAlex and DBLP) could not be queried (Section 3.1), and Web of Science, the ACM Digital Library and IEEE Xplore were not searched. Scopus indexes few of the preprints and proceedings in which this field publishes, so most database records came from arXiv and Semantic Scholar. The web searches that supplied 149 studies have unquantifiable coverage, and their record counts depend on the number of queries run. Non-English work is probably under-represented.

Search sensitivity. Two-thirds of the studies included from the web phase were not retrieved by the database query. Most of them belong to adjacent streams, such as chain-of-thought faithfulness, probing and AI control, that the query was deliberately not designed to cover, but the figure also shows that construct terminology in the field is unstable and that a term-based search alone would have missed relevant work.

Rule-assisted screening. Stage 1 excluded records without any phenomenon term in the title or abstract. The audit sample and the rescue pass limit, but do not eliminate, the risk that relevant records described in unusual terms were excluded.

Depth of reading. Full texts were read for the 37 anchor studies only. The other included studies were charted from titles and abstracts, which may misstate methods or omit qualifications.

Single-reviewer screening. Screening and charting were performed by one reviewer assisted by an AI system, without dual independent assessment. Inter-pass agreement ($\kappa = 0.747$) and rule-versus-manual layer agreement ($\kappa = 0.881$) were measured within this single-reviewer process; they are not substitutes for inter-rater reliability.

Assignment simplification. Multi-method and multi-layer studies were assigned a single primary layer and method family.

Evidence base. Three-quarters of the included studies are preprints. Several anchor findings come from a small number of research groups and from developer-produced reports whose methods are not fully disclosed.

Recency. The field is moving quickly; the search date was 9 October 2026, and later studies are not included.

The most useful next steps for this review are dual independent screening of the database records and full-text charting beyond the anchor set.

8 Conclusion

Model-originated threats to evaluation validity have moved from theoretical concern to an active empirical field in less than three years. The evidence charted here shows that LLMs can recognise evaluations, that recognition can change behaviour, and that current detection methods are unreliable against adversarially constructed underperformance. It also shows that “evaluation awareness” is not one quantity, that its relationship to behaviour is model-specific, and that most validity evidence rests on behaviour that was deliberately induced. For practitioners, the immediate implications are to report awareness measures separately and with their biases, to prefer elicitation-first protocols for capability claims, and to treat propensity-based safety results as upper bounds on safety when awareness is plausible. For researchers, the priority is to establish whether methods validated on induced behaviour transfer to behaviour that arises from training incentives.

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Data availability All search queries, record logs, screening decisions, charting data and count reconciliations are provided as supplementary material and in the public repository accompanying this article (Supplementary Files S1–S4).

Code availability The scripts used for the database searches (`search/run_searches.py`), deduplication (`search/dedup.py`), screening and reconciliation (`screening/screen_db.py`, `screening/merge.py`, `screening/reliability.py`, `evidence/screen.py`), charting (`evidence/chart.py`) and figure generation (`evidence/figures.py`) are provided in the accompanying repository, together with the raw API responses.

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